

Introduction

Since the earliest days of human existence, structures have been made to provide shelter, warmth, refuge and privacy, and to facilitate worship, work and social interaction. In this respect, little has changed – but in terms of development, expression, interpretation and style, everything is in constant flux. This is what makes architecture so fascinating: although our essential requirements barely alter, different times, place and cultures have produced hugely varied buildings. The factors behind this variety include religious beliefs, availability of materials, variations in climate, limits of technology and economic systems. Among the most enduring works of architecture are castles, palaces and cathedrals, many of which are physical proof of technological progress. Buildings are not just about the way they look; they are also about how they function, their practicality, construction, decoration and how they fit into the landscape.

Architecture in Minutes is a brief introduction to some of the greatest architectural achievements of humankind. From the mysterious megaliths and spectacular pyramids of the ancient world, to the formidable fortresses and soaring Gothic churches of medieval Europe, and from elegant pagodas and magnificent mosques and palaces, to intricate urban developments and towering skyscrapers, this book surveys ideas, innovations and ingenuity. It considers society's changing requirements and expectations, as well as many of the architects who, through their knowledge of construction methods and materials and their understanding of proportion, aesthetics and local environments, have created unique and original buildings, instigating further change and developments over time.

In these pages, you will find iconic works of architecture, such as the Colosseum in Rome, the Parthenon in Athens and the Taj Mahal in Agra. Also explored are the architectural movements such as mannerism, neoclassicism and modernism, that put individual buildings into context, and certain exemplary architects, including Andrea Palladio, Frank Lloyd Wright and Le Corbusier. There are also lesser-known structures, movements and architects, providing an overview to consider, enjoy and hopefully inspire you to further investigate the fascinating world of architecture.